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CoARA 2023-24 at Stockholm University

Astrid Söderbergh Widding, President of Stockholm University

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Preamble

Stockholm University signed CoARA in 2022. This report constitutes the Stockholm University report on its CoARA related activities from the start until today. Substantial parts of Stockholm University's strategy, organization, and assessment processes align with the guiding principles of CoARA, as illustrated in this report. The document has been developed based on a collaborative work, and is organized based on the themes of Organizational Issues, Quality Assurance System for Research, Recruitments and Promotions, Staff Scientists and Senior Staff Scientists, and Activities During 2024.

Organizational Issues – Trust-Based Collegial Governance

A basic prerequisite for acting upon the issues identified in CoARA is to maintain and develop an efficient organization of the university. Stockholm University strives to have a simple organization with broad mandates and clear responsibilities at each level of decision-making. The fundamental collegial decision-making should be combined with a strong leadership from departmental chairs, deans and the university management team. The interactions between these levels are key for the development of the university, "Leadership for change is neither top down nor bottom up but across and throughout." to quote John Hudzik, former Dean at Michigan State University. Close interaction with an efficient support structure provided both within each department and from the university centrally is essential.

Stockholm University's governance structure ensures developed forms of dialogue within the different organizational parts of the university. The efficiency resulting from this constitutes a cornerstone in the university's efforts toward quality assurance. The collegial structure and culture fosters engagement and a sense of responsibility among the staff for the university's overall operations. Additionally, it facilitates an understanding within the university leadership of the diverse conditions and opportunities within departments, enabling flexible management based on prevailing circumstance.

Furthermore, the university conducts comprehensive structured work on strategies, action plans, and operational follow-up, which serves as quality assurance. University researchers operate within a constantly changing system governed by scientific, political, and financial conditions and goals, as well as current societal challenges. To ensure and develop operations, the organization and methods must allow for flexible adjustments of research to these dynamic circumstances. This is a significant reason for choosing to work based on trust, peer-review, leveraging the organization's extensive knowledge of the challenges, opportunities, contexts, and conditions of the operations.

The majority of research peer-review takes place in the day-to-day operations of each university department. This involves the examination of publications, grant applications, dissertations, recruitment matters, promotions, and regular thematic evaluations through third-party entities, such as the Swedish Research Council. Researchers at Stockholm

University are also regularly involved as experts and reviewers in grant applications for research councils and the research quality of other institutions. The extensive expertise of Stockholm University's researchers, coupled with their in-depth knowledge of the internal context, enables them to actively participate in internal quality assessment processes. Nevertheless, external reviewers are also engaged in quality-assurance processes, which will be further developed below.

Quality Assurance System for Research

The Swedish Higher Education Authority, a government agency responsible for official statistics and monitoring compliance with laws and regulations among Swedish Higher Education Institutions (HEIs), is currently evaluating all the HEI's quality assurance processes for research. The evaluation process is conducted at each HEI and encompasses all academic disciplines. The evaluation is one component of Sweden's national system for quality assurance in higher education and research as initiated by the Government. The evaluation thus emanates from a government mandate and corresponds to a broader trend characterized by a growing prevalence of assessments and evaluations within the public sector. In adapting to these new requirements and developments, many universities are conducting their own university wide research evaluations. As a consequence, a considerable amount of time and effort is invested in these evaluations, both internally within each HEI and externally by external reviewers.

In light of this development, Stockholm University has chosen a different approach, where the utility of the evaluations, as well as the safeguarding of the organization's time and resources, has been prioritized. Thus, Stockholm University utilizes existing available data collected from national sources such as Statistics Sweden, the Swedish Research Council, and the Swedish Higher Education Authority, along with internally collected university data. The data is compiled into institution-specific reports. The data pertains to the research operations of the departments and their diverse research environments. This includes information on grants received from major peer-reviewing bodies for research funding in Sweden and the EU, and recruitment data from within the university. Notably, the main focus of the process is not on bibliometric data. The data is automatically updated each year, thus minimizing the workload. Based on this information, complemented by brief additions from the department chairs, "quality dialogues" are conducted between the university management team and department managements. Naturally, in these dialogues, the participants' general knowledge about the specific conditions, problems, and opportunities for each department is crucial, and the data may serve as a starting point or an incentive to address particular issues. A first round of such dialogues with all the departments has just been completed. Building upon the insights gained from the initial round of dialogues, the process has been further developed in 2024 through discussions between the university management, the deans, and department chairs, which has resulted in a new "rules-and-regulations" document on the process as a whole.

This university-wide regular process is complemented by "focused research assessments", primarily targeting selected departments and research environments, but it could also be directed to university-wide issues such as recruitments and promotions. The selection for these evaluations is made based on the collected data, the dialogues and the general knowledge of the university management. It is oriented towards both problems and

opportunities, and external referees are employed. The evaluations are performed in close collaboration and dialogue with representatives of the assessed department or research environments and their leadership. Prior to the assessment, external reviewers receive a self-evaluation from the department or research environment. The final assessment report addresses both strengths and weaknesses.

So far six such focused research assessments have been performed and a number of new assessments are underway. The assessments have resulted in specific recommendations that are being followed up. This system of quality assurance has received strong support from the department chairs, not the least as it minimizes their workload whilst providing fruitful conditions for the advancement of research. Overall, we believe that targeted actions, such as well-chosen focus evaluations, are more likely to bring about desired changes and development than university-wide evaluations. In sum, the assessments within the quality assurance system for research are primarily grounded in qualitative evaluation, with peer review playing a central role, while incorporating quantitative indicators in a responsible way.

Recruitments and Promotions

Stockholm University has for a period of time focused on developing its recruitment and promotion system within the very special and rather restrictive national system regulated by laws and provisions under which most Swedish HEIs operate (the majority are public-sector HEIs, and thus are public authorities answering directly to the Government).

Sweden only recently established the legal possibility of a proper tenure track system. The evaluation for tenure is of course crucial and it is particularly demanding when there is not a tradition of taking the difficult decisions to deny promotion. A system was set up within Stockholm University where a large number of leading international specialists are asked to give short reports on the scientific proficiency of the candidate whereas the pedagogical proficiency is evaluated within the university. Crucial here is that the experts are chosen so that they are close enough to the scientific field of the candidate to be able to easily understand the work. This process is rather different from the Swedish tradition of evaluating applicants to a position and promotions by two or three external experts that may be less versed in the specific field of the applicant. These reports are also increasingly based on bibliometric data, contrary to our instructions.

Staff Scientists and Senior Staff Scientists

Research requires a support from dedicated support personal. The people providing this support typically have a strong science background and it is important to have a system that acknowledges their crucial roles. Sweden has a heavily regulated labor market that makes promotions difficult, but in spite of this Stockholm University has now introduced the two positions of Staff Scientist and Senior Staff Scientist within a promotion system.

Activities Accomplished During 2024

- Focus evaluation of the Department of Physics, initiated in 2023 and completed in 2024.

- Follow up on the effect of the five-year post PhD time-limit for recruitment to tenure track positions, which due to a proposed change from the Swedish government to go back to the seven-year limit is on hold.
- Follow up on the promotion of tenure track assistant professors to tenured associate professors, in particular on the evaluations.
- Securing the future of Stockholm University's arctic research station at Tarfala, by a change of organizational residency within the university. This is a result of one of the focus evaluations, the one on Geomorphology and Glaciology.
- Organizational change of the Faculty and the Department of Law, as a result of one of the focus evaluations, the one on the Faculty of Law.
- Follow up and adjustment the processes for quality dialogues with department management, completed by recent decision by the University Presidency.

